



SAFETY TOOLBOX TALK

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Topic:	EXCAVATIONS				

This briefing is not intended to tell you how to do your jobs, it is designed to help keep you safe. We want everybody to be able to return home safely to their family and friends at the end of each day.

- Do not work in an excavation unless it is safe to do so.
- Use gangways provided for crossing excavations. Do not jump across.
- Do not stand on struts.
- Do not interfere with or alter the positioning of barriers or supports in excavations or trenches unless authorised to do so.
- Barriers must be provided around any excavation, manholes or other openings.
- On sites where the general public, and particularly children, are likely to gain access or have a right of way, barriers to excavations must be at least 950mm high.
- Be careful of slipping when using ladders in trenches, especially in wet and greasy condition. All ladders must be secured and extend at least 1.07m (3'6") above landing.
- Keep gangways clear and free from rubbish at all times.
- Do not drive vehicles close to or along the edges of excavations. When vehicles are working near the edges of excavations, chocks should be positioned to prevent tipping vehicles overriding or falling in.
- Never work in an excavation unless it is timbered or battered to a safe angle, or in solid rock.
- Never work beyond the supported sides of an excavation. If an excavating machine is being used, always face it.
- Keep working areas, above and alongside trenches or excavations, clear of objects or loose materials.
- Ensure that timber for supporting trenches is sound. See that nails have been removed or hammered down.
- Always use ladders to get into and out of excavations.
- Do not climb on the timbering and never jump across.
- Before digging make sure that the location of water, gas, electricity and telephone services is known.
- Keep spoils heaps well away from the edges of excavation.
- Do not place materials, including tools, on or near the edges of excavations: remember the people working below.
- Never work in an unsupported excavation unless the slope of the sides is sufficient to prevent a dangerous fall of earth.
- Always wear your hard hat when working in an excavation.

Discussion Points

What must you check for prior to excavating?

What precautions must be taken when dumpers are tipping spoil back into a trench?